with Australia. However, we are not able to do the same with New Zealand at the moment. Where do the roadblocks lie, and do you think you could look at a similar trade agreement in the near future?
One challenge is that one of our biggest exports are dairy products, and there the domestic interests of India and New Zealand do not find a middle ground. But there are other opportunities. For example, New Zealand has a well-developed horticulture sector—there might be opportunities there.

Q. During the pandemic, there were lots of constraints for students who came back and could not return in time for classes. Has that issue been sorted out? Secondly, will mobility and migration to New Zealand now ease?
After Jaishankar raised the students' issue with me and the immigration minister during his visit, we identified 1,800 places for post-study work visas to be allocated to many students who were unable to take up post-study work because of Covid. On the broader question of labour mobility, we are not in a position right now to provide a labour mobility response to India's requests. We are undergoing a resetting of our immigration criteria and part of it is our inherent desire to train locally. But that might not be achievable in some key sectors. So, we will revisit this issue at an appropriate time.

"We are restting our immigration criteria and part of it is to train locally. We are currently not in a position to provide a labour mobility response to India's requests"

Q. You have a very strong relationship with China and there was a reluctance to move closer to the Quad and the Indo-Pacific strategy. Where does New Zealand stand on this issue now?
New Zealand sees India as a key contributor to regional stability in the Indo-Pacific. We welcome India's contribution to the Quad arrangement and recognise it as important for our region. We have other ways in which we collaborate with Quad members. We have bilateral ties with India, Australia, Japan, Canada, the UK and the US. The Quad has a specific purpose and we are not part of that arrangement and that is okay. It doesn't stop us from talking with members of the Quad and other relations enable us to work with like-minded nations in a number of ways.

Q. Earlier, India perceived New Zealand to be close to China and highly dependent on it in terms of trade....
New Zealand has had a free trade agreement with China since 2009. They are our largest trading partner. The relationship is not only economic, it's a complex, maturing relationship. There are things that we can and cannot agree on. But we are open about it. We are respectful, consistent and predictable in the way that relationship exists. While there are trade benefits, there are challenging issues that test our relationship.

Q. Compared with New Zealand's broad-spectrum ties with China, what do you see when you look at India-New Zealand ties? They haven't taken off in a big way; in fact, one can say they are underwhelming.
No, it's in a new phase. And we have an opportunity to take the relationship to the next level and identifying that we shouldn't hinge the relationship purely on a free trade agreement. There are other economic opportunities to explore beyond that too.

Q. What is New Zealand's approach when it sees India maintaining ties with Russia as war rages in Ukraine? Is that impacting the India-New Zealand relationship?
India's relationship with other countries is a matter for India. New Zealand's stand is that we support Ukraine in its endeavour to protect its territorial integrity. We do not support Russia's unjust, unprovoked and immoral invasion of Ukraine. Ultimately, it comes to the core principles that hold us all together. We have got to uphold international rules and norms.

Q. There are concerns that China is getting aggressive over Taiwan. Has there been a dialogue on this between you?
China knows very well our views about the South China Sea. We uphold UNCLOS (the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea) and registered this view formally with the United Nations. So, China is under no shadow of a doubt about our views.

Q. How have communal relations in New Zealand been since the 2019 mosque attack in Christchurch? What steps has the government taken?
We undertook a world commission to look at the attacks and there were recommendations arising out of it about improving the government's role to ensure greater cohesion. We want a more inclusive, diverse society that we are proud to call our New Zealand. But it's an ongoing task.

Q. Are you disappointed that former PM Jacinda Ardern put in her papers? You worked with her very closely.
She has achieved a lot in the five years she was PM and we acknowledge it. She called time on her leadership for a number of personal as well as public reasons, which the New Zealand public were made aware of, and we respect that decision.

Q. Do you think there will be continuity in ties with India even if the Labour Party doesn't come back to power?
I would like to think so. This is where the diaspora community becomes very influential because it holds every government to account. We're hearing through our 250,000-strong Indian diaspora community that the relationship with India must be valued. New Zealand is a small country, unlike India. India has a key role to play to ensure peace, stability and prosperity in an important region. That's how we see India. ■